

Oviraptorosaurs

The oviraptorosaurs are a family of odd-looking, feathered dinosaurs with parrotlike beaks. Although they evolved from flesh-eating dinosaurs (theropods), they were omnivores or plant-eaters. They had few or no teeth, short snouts, and often a decorative crest on the head. Fossils show they brooded their eggs as birds do. Some oviraptorosaurs were so birdlike that the scientists who discovered them thought they must be ancient flightless birds.

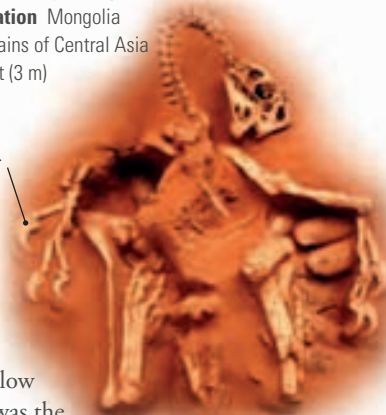
Citipati

SIH-tee-PAH-tee



- **When** 75 million years ago (Late Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** Mongolia
- **Habitat** Plains of Central Asia
- **Length** 9 ft (3 m)

*Claws at tips
of long fingers*



The most distinctive feature of *Citipati* (below and right) was the crest on its head.

Many *Citipati* specimens have been found crouching on their eggs in nests, sheltering them with arms that were probably feathered, as modern birds do. *Citipati*'s oval eggs were huge—even bigger than a man's hand.



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Short skull, sometimes with a crest
- Parrotlike beaks with small or no teeth
- Feathers
- Plant eaters

When

Oviraptorosaurs lived in the Cretaceous Period, between 84 and 65 million years ago.